Sundarananda Thakura

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Nityananda's Intimate Servant

Sundarananda Thakura is one of the twelve gopalas, the closest and most intimate companions of Nityananda Prabhu, and his name is known throughout the Vaishnava world. In some lists of the gopalas he stands twelfth, in others second. All twelve, in the words of one of the biographies, held the seats of chief ministers (patra-raja) in the royal assembly of the Vaishnavas of the world.

The word itself explains who the gopalas are: it is the name of the cowherd friends of Krishna and Balarama in Vraja. The mahajanas count the twelve gopalas among the companions of Baladeva, who came into the world as Nityananda, and Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami says of Nityananda's whole circle:

“All the companions of Sri Nityananda were formerly cowherd boys in Vraja. Each of them had a staff and a horn; they wore the dress of cowherds, and peacock feathers adorned their hair.” (CC, Adi 11.21)

Sundarananda is Baladeva's eternal companion in the pastimes of Vraja, and with Him he came into the pastimes of Nityananda. The “Chaitanya-charitamrita,” where Krishnadasa Kaviraja counts the branches of Nityananda's tree, says of him:

“Sundarananda, a branch of Sri Nityananda, is known as one of His closest servants. With him Nityananda performed deeds that repeated the pastimes of Vraja.” (CC, Adi 11.23)

He was one of those to whom Nityananda's heart lay open, and with him Nityananda enjoyed the playful pastimes of Vraja. Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, who called himself the last servant of Nityananda, names him the foremost in His circle:

“Sundarananda was an ocean of the rasas of divine love. He was the foremost among the companions of Nityananda Prabhu.” (CB, Antya 5.728)

Maheshpur

Sundarananda appeared in the village of Maheshpur in the district of Yashohar (Jessore). The village once belonged to the district of Nadia and now belongs to Yashohar. Maheshpur lies about thirteen miles east of Majdiya station (formerly called Shivanivas) on the Eastern Bengal Railway.[1] From Kotchandpur it is about six miles by boat and about nine on foot.

In the Pastimes of the Lord and of Nityananda

In the padas Sundarananda is seen beside Mahaprabhu already in Navadvipa. In Vasu Ghosha he is among the cowherd boys in the goshtha-lila, when Gorachanda, remembering His former pastimes, calls the cows; and in the padas on the Nanda-utsava in the house of Shrivasa, quoted in the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” the Lord, dressed as a cowherd, celebrates Krishna's birth, and Sundara dances with the other gopalas, a carrying pole on his shoulders.

When the Lord accepted sannyasa, Sundarananda, according to Jayananda, went away together with Nityananda, Ramadasa and Parameshvara. And when Nityananda went to Gauda and filled it with sankirtana, Sundarananda was among His companions. Murari Gupta (“Kadacha” 4.22) names him among the cowherd friends at Panihati when Raghava Pandita bathed and adorned Nityananda. His name also stands in the lists of Nityananda's branches — in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” (Adi 11) and in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 5).

He was with Nityananda, too, at the famous chida-dadhi festival at Panihati, where Raghunatha Dasa fed everyone flat rice with yogurt. Counting Nityananda's companions at that festival, Krishnadasa Kaviraja names:

“Ramadasa, Sundarananda, Gadadhara Dasa, Murari, Kamalakara, Sadashiva and Purandara.” (CC, Antya 6.61)

The “Nityananda-vamsha-vistara” tells how Jahnava Devi, setting out for Ekachakra, called Ramadasa, Ramai, Sundarananda and Jnanadasa to go with her; and later, when Virachandra set out for Vrindavana, he sent Ramai, Sundarananda and other companions back to Khardaha. The “Prema-vilasa” mentions him as well.

Divine Madness

Like Nityananda, Sundarananda lived from early childhood in the mood of an avadhuta — a wanderer not bound by outward rules — going everywhere and preaching the kirtana of Krishna. Like Nityananda, he delivered the most fallen.

He possessed great power. His best-known wonder is preserved by Devakinandana in his “Vaishnava-vandana”:

“With great hope I shall praise Sundarananda Thakura: he made kadamba flowers bloom on a lemon tree.” (“Vaishnava-vandana” of Devakinandana, 84)[2]

These flowers, it is said, he afterwards offered in the service of the Deity Radha-ramana.

Tradition adds that in the divine madness of love he would catch crocodiles and bring them along with him; once he dived into a river and pulled out a crocodile. Jayananda writes of the same. He would also, it is said, catch tigers of the forest and let them hear the name of Hari in their ears.[3]

There is nothing of a display of power in these wonders: this was how his intoxication with love for Krishna showed itself. An avadhuta and preacher of kirtana like Nityananda Himself, he gave his very power to the deliverance of the fallen.

Deities, Disciples and Kin

Sundarananda installed the Deity of Sri Sri Radha-vallabha in Maheshpur. It is said that the gosvamis of Saidabad later took Him away to their village, and that afterwards the present Deity appeared in Maheshpur. In another part of the village Sri Sri Radha-vallabha and Sri Sri Radha-ramana are served to this day; the service is overseen by the local zamindars, lands and an endowment (vritti) are set aside for it, and the puja is performed by devalas — hired temple priests.[4]

Sundarananda lived as a brihad-vrati — one who has taken the great vow of lifelong celibacy: he never married and left no descendants. The descendants of his kinsmen, however, live in the village of Mangaldihi in the district of Birbhum and serve Sri Sri Balarama Jiu there. The gosvamis of Saidabad call themselves descendants of his disciple.[5]

The Shripata Today

Of the ancient sacred sites of Maheshpur only one has survived — the place where he appeared (avirbhava-pitha). A grove of Tulasi grows there and a neem tree stands, and nearby, with the permission of the local zamindars, a certain baul has settled.

On the 10th of Phalguna, 1331 of the Bengali era (about February 1925), during the Gauda-mandala-parikrama, devotees led by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura came here. They stayed at the shripata, heard his hari-katha and held a great festival of sankirtana. An account of the visit

was printed in the journal “Gaudiya” (4th year, no. 45).

Departure

Accounts of the day of Sundarananda's departure differ. According to our calendar, the disappearance day of Srila Sundarananda Thakura is observed on the purnima of the month of Damodara (Kartika), the day of the Rasa-yatra.[6] Where his samadhi is, the biographies do not say.

Sudama

Who he is in Krishna's eternal pastimes is revealed by Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika”:

“He who was formerly called Sudama is now Thakura Sundara; and the friend Vasudama is Pandita Sri Dhananjaya.” (GGD 127)

Sudama is a friend (sakha) of Krishna and Balarama. Srila Rupa Gosvami describes him in the “Radha-Krishna-ganoddesha-dipika”: his complexion has a faint golden hue and a captivating lustre; he wears blue and is adorned with jewels; his father is Matuka and his mother Rochana; he is a handsome youth (kishora), eager to taste the rasa of the most varied pastimes. (“Radha-Krishna-ganoddesha-dipika,” Laghu 40–41)

So his whole life is read from Vraja: the cowherd boy Sudama, Balarama's friend, came with Him into the pastimes of Nityananda and remained His intimate servant.

1. According to another biography, Maheshpur stands on the river Betravati (Vetravati), fourteen miles east of Majdiya station.

2. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 5), the kadamba bloomed on the lemon tree by the will of Nityananda Himself, in the house of Raghava Pandita at Panihati; so too in the vandana of Srila Jiva Gosvami, and in the biographies themselves, in their account of Nityananda. It is Devakinandana, and after him the biographies in their chapters on Sundarananda, who ascribe this miracle to Sundarananda.

3. In the vandanas (tripadi 73–74; the Sanskrit vandana, 96) it is not Sundarananda himself but his servant who brings the tiger and lets it hear the name of Hari.

4. According to another biography, the priests took both Deities — Radha-vallabha and Radha-ramana — to Saidabad and installed a wooden Deity in Maheshpur.

5. According to another biography, they are descendants of his disciples, and they still conduct the service at Maheshpur.

6. According to one of the biographies, his departure is celebrated differently in different places: on Magha purnima, on the krishna-ekadashi of the month of Pausha, or on Kartika purnima. In Maheshpur itself it is observed on the krishna-ekadashi of Pausha with an eight-prahara (round-the-clock) kirtana.